METHODOLOGY

HOW THE UNIVERSITIES WERE RANKED

With 655 general, 79 medical, 192 technical and 27 law universities on its radar, the India Today Group's annual rankings of Best Universities are a crucial barometer of the country's higher education universe. The rich information and data therein not only make it easier for aspirants to take critical career decisions, it also benefits other stakeholders such as recruiters, parents, alumni, policymakers and people at large.

INDIA TODAY's knowledge partner Marketing and Development Research Associates (MDRA), a reputed research agency, followed a rigorous methodology while conducting this survey between January 2024 and July 2024. For the objective ranking, MDRA carefully attuned 120+ attributes to arrive at a comprehensive and balanced comparison of universities. These attributes were clubbed under five broad parameters—'Reputation & Governance', 'Academic & Research Excellence', 'Infrastructure & Living Experience', 'Personality and Leadership Development' and 'Career Progression and Placement'. The rankings were based on the data the universities provided for the current year.

A list of 750+ universities fulfilling the criteria was prepared. Postgraduate courses under four streams—general, medical, technical and law—were considered for evaluation. Only universities offering full-time, in-classroom courses and having a minimum of three pass-out batches by the end of 2023 qualified.

Experts with rich experience in their fields were consulted to frame the parameters and sub-parameters for the respective categories of universities. After meticulously determining the indicators, their relative weights were finalised.

A comprehensive objective questionnaire was sent to qualifying universities and also uploaded on the MDRA and INDIA TODAY websites. As many as 174 universities submitted their data and supporting documents within the stipulated deadline.

After receiving the objective data from universities, the supporting documents were scrutinised extensively and the data verified through every possible means. An objective score was given to each university under the five indicators. While computing objective scores, it was ensured that aggregate data alone was not used and hence data was normalised.

The overview of universities in the INDIA TODAY rankings not only helps aspirants make crucial career decisions but also stakeholders to frame policy

A perceptual survey was carried out among well-informed 320 respondents (35 chancellors/vice-chancellors, 79 directors/deans/registrars, 206 senior faculty (professors and heads of departments) across 20+ cities divided into four zones.

- **North: Delhi-NCR, Lucknow, Jaipur, Chandigarh**
- **West: Mumbai, Pune, Ahmedabad, Indore**
- **South: Chennai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Coimbatore**
- **East: Kolkata, Bhubaneswar, Guwahati, Patna**

National and zonal rankings were taken from them in their respective field of experience and given 75 per cent and 25 per cent weightage respectively. They also rated the universities on a 10-point scale on each of the five parameters. The total scores arrived from the objective and perception survey were added in the ratio of 50:50 to get the total combined score. The MDRA core team led by Executive Director Abhishek Agrawal included Project Director Abnish Jha, Deputy Research Manager Vaibhav Gupta, Assistant Research Executive Abhay Pratap Singh Rawat, Assistant Research Executive Mahak Gupta and Senior Executive-EDP Manveer Singh. ■